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COMMONWEALTH OF THE NORTHERN MARIANA ISLANDS
Department of Commerce
DATE: 6/11/2025 TIME: 12:09 AM/PM
REGISTRAR OF CORPORATION

Dear CMS Administrator Dr. Mehmet Oz and the Health IT Modernization Team,

Thank you for the opportunity to provide input on the Request for Information (RFI) regarding CMS's Health Information Technology Modernization initiative.

On behalf of the **Uraali Refaluwasch Association (URAALI)**, a culturally rooted non-profit organization based in the **Commonwealth of the Northern Mariana Islands (CNMI)**, we write to advocate for the **inclusive engagement of U.S. territories** in this national initiative. URAALI is a 501(c)(3)-equivalent entity certified under CNMI Business License No. 27006, dedicated to community empowerment, cultural preservation, and indigenous advocacy.

Key Recommendations:

1. **Inclusion of CNMI Cross-Sector Partners**:

   CMS should actively engage with and support local agencies that serve as critical pillars in healthcare delivery and coordination within the CNMI, including:

   - The **CNMI Office of Vocational Rehabilitation (OVR)**, which provides essential support for individuals with disabilities to achieve independent living and employment;
   - The **CNMI Office on Aging**, housed under the **Department of Community and Cultural Affairs (DCCA)**, which serves a growing elder population and family caregivers in need of integrated services;
   - The **CNMI Department of Corrections (DOC)**, which is responsible for the health and welfare of **incarcerated adults and juveniles**. Including this population in digital health strategies is crucial to ensuring continuity of care, behavioral health access, and reintegration success.

2. **Equity in Health IT Funding and Support**:

   CMS should ensure full access for U.S. territories to participate in **funding, pilot programs, and technical assistance** under this modernization initiative. The CNMI's

healthcare system, led by the **Commonwealth Healthcare Corporation (CHCC)**, faces unique resource and connectivity constraints that require tailored support.

3. **Cultural and Geographic Sensitivity in System Design**:

   In territories like the CNMI, where cultural values, extended family caregiving, and inter-agency collaboration are central to service delivery, CMS must design systems with **flexibility and cultural competence**. URAALI urges CMS to consider these factors when shaping policy and technological frameworks.

4. **Territorial Listening Sessions and Representation**:

   We respectfully request that CMS host targeted listening sessions or establish regional advisory roles that include CNMI-based stakeholders—government agencies, non-profits, technology partners, and patient advocacy groups—to ensure our voice is heard in shaping national health IT priorities.

Closing Statement:

As a community-based organization grounded in indigenous values and grassroots experience, **URAALI** believes that health information modernization must reach and reflect the realities of **every community under CMS jurisdiction.** That includes the families, caregivers, elders, and underserved populations of the CNMI.

Si Yu'us Ma'åse and Ghilissow me Olomwaay, for your leadership and for considering this public comment from the Commonwealth of the Marianas.

Respectfully submitted,

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Senior Practitioner & Advisor

Uraali Refaluwasch Association (URAALI)

With the concurrence of the URAALI Officers:

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